

# SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: ARKANSAS TECH UNIVERSITY

## TRADITIONAL AND ALTERNATIVE

On-Site Review: September 24-27, 2024

### WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

| PERFORMANCE LEVEL      | WHAT THE RATING MEANS                                                                                    |
|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>4 — EXCEEDS</b>     | Coursework and training <b>CONSISTENTLY</b> address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.     |
| <b>3 — MEETS</b>       | Coursework and training <b>USUALLY</b> address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.          |
| <b>2 — APPROACHING</b> | Coursework and training <b>INCONSISTENTLY</b> address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.   |
| <b>1 — BELOW</b>       | Coursework and training <b>RARELY OR DO NOT</b> address the characteristics of high-quality instruction. |

# ARKANSAS TECH UNIVERSITY

## TRADITIONAL

| REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS       |                                          |                                         |
|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| REVIEW AREA 1<br>LITERACY COURSEWORK | REVIEW AREA 2<br>FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES | REVIEW AREA 3<br>PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT |
| MEETS                                | MEETS                                    | MEETS                                   |
| CRITERIA REVIEWED                    |                                          |                                         |
| 9                                    | 11                                       | 7                                       |

## PROGRAM INFORMATION

|                  |                                                         |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| INSTITUTION NAME | Arkansas Tech University                                |
| LOCATION         | Russellville, Arkansas                                  |
| PROGRAM REVIEWED | Educator preparation program, literacy (elementary K-6) |
| PATHWAY          | Traditional                                             |
| REVIEW FRAMEWORK | TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2024)        |
| REVIEWING BODY   | Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)                     |
| SITE VISIT DATES | September 24-27, 2024                                   |

# REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY COURSEWORK

| REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                    |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|
| <b>MEETS</b>   9 criteria reviewed                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                    |
| CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                    |
| Overview of the science of reading                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Concepts of print instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Collaborative communication, oral language instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Fluency instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Vocabulary instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Text comprehension instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Writing instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | <b>Approaching</b> |
| WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                    |
| <p>Reviewers found that two courses, RDNG 3003 Teaching Literacy Foundations and RDNG 4003 Literacy Assessment and Intervention, trained candidates well in the science of reading and spiraled the literacy components across both. Candidates studied and compared the Simple View of Reading, Scarborough's Reading Rope, and the Four-Part Processing Model. Faculty labeled and modeled instruction, and candidates practiced through scenarios, peer teaching, videotaped lessons, and a library of high-quality instructional materials. Candidates learned to administer DIBELS, PAST, MAZE, the Core Phonics Survey, and DSA writing assessments and to plan instruction from the results. Reviewers rated concepts of print and writing instruction lower, finding that the courses needed greater focus on writing across the curriculum and on strategies for multilingual learners.</p> |                    |
| REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                    |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Select and implement</li> <li>• Model and rehearse</li> <li>• Use, collect, and analyze</li> <li>• Plan and teach</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |                    |

## REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

| REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                    |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|
| <b>MEETS</b>   11 criteria reviewed                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                    |
| CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                    |
| Selection of clinical placement schools                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Selection of cooperating teachers (mentor teachers)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Field-based placements provide opportunities to use HQIM                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Responsibilities build to candidate readiness for full responsibility                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Mentor teachers are skillful and can coach candidates                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Faculty and supervisors guide and evaluate candidates through training                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Quality of written and oral feedback                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | <b>Meets</b>       |
| WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                    |
| <p>Reviewers found that the program placed most candidates in high-performing or improving schools with diverse student bodies, and that mentor teachers were selected against criteria the program and schools agreed on and were dropped from the rotation when they did not model effective practice. Candidates used high-quality instructional materials such as Foundations and Wit and Wisdom in placements, supported by a university materials library. Field experience taken alongside RDNG 4003, then Residency A and Residency B, gave candidates a structured gradual release into full responsibility. Written feedback had improved since the previous inspection, though oral feedback sometimes centered on classroom management. Opportunities to apply learning with multilingual children were inconsistent.</p> |                    |
| REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |                    |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Expand on existing work</li> <li>• Train evaluators</li> <li>• Monitor</li> <li>• Provide support</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                    |

## REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

| REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                    |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|
| <b>MEETS</b>   7 criteria reviewed                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |                    |
| CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                    |
| Quality of data the program collects and uses                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Internal quality control gates (or checkpoints) and intervention plans                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Quality of monitoring                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Monitoring coursework quality, teaching quality, and clinical connections                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Quality improvement planning                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | <b>Exceeds</b>     |
| Partnerships improve candidate experiences with HQIM                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | <b>Approaching</b> |
| WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                    |
| <p>Reviewers found that the program collected reliable data from state and cooperative surveys and from evaluator observation records, and used it to improve feedback quality, evaluator training, and the infusion of science of reading content through the literacy courses. Four internal checkpoints governed candidate progress, from prerequisite coursework and background checks through internship and licensure, with documented action plans for candidates who struggled. Improvement planning was the strongest element, supported by a tracked database of action plans with measurable goals reviewed with the teacher education council and district partners. Reviewers found monitoring of observation and feedback data insufficiently rigorous and partnership evaluation surveys not specific enough about literacy field experiences.</p> |                    |
| REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                    |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Review data</li> <li>• Develop targets</li> <li>• Create training</li> <li>• Monitor and evaluate</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                    |

Sources: TPI-US Written Report & Recommendations, Arkansas Tech University, September 24-27, 2024, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2024). Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.